

Stirling Old Town Walk - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Stirling's Old Town: An Optional Walk Downhill

If your legs are willing and the light is good, here is a walk that turns one great sight into two. Everything you have just seen up in the castle happened at the top of a very steep street, and that street is the old town of Stirling, tumbling down the tail of the crag toward the river. You can walk the whole of it in well under an hour, all downhill, and it is arguably the finest surviving medieval townscape in Scotland.

From the esplanade, the route is simply this: follow the road down. Within a minute or two you reach the grand ruined face of Mar's Wark and, tucked just behind it, the medieval town church, the Church of the Holy Rude, with its old graveyard spilling down the hillside. Below the church stands the Old Town Jail. Keep going and the street becomes Broad Street, the old marketplace, with its market cross and its Tolbooth, the little building that was town hall, courtroom and prison all at once. From there you can carry on down through the lower town, or slip onto the Back Walk, the old path that hugs the surviving town wall, and follow it round toward the Old Bridge, the stone crossing that inherited the job of Wallace's famous timber one.

The old town is the whole story seen from below. Up in the castle you met kings and queens and the great sweep of Scottish history. Down here you meet the town that fed them, jailed its thieves, sold its cloth, buried its dead, and once crowned a king in its parish church. Same hill, same centuries, a completely different view. Whenever you're ready, let's walk down.

The Church Where a King Was Crowned

Step into the Church of the Holy Rude and you are standing in the second oldest building in Stirling, after the castle itself. There has been a church on this spot since 1129, though the one around you was rebuilt in the early fourteen hundreds, after fire swept through the old town. Look up. That dark oak roof, held together not with nails but with wooden pegs, is the oldest surviving timber roof of its kind in Scotland. It has hung over this nave for six centuries.

Now for the moment that makes this church extraordinary. Up in the castle, you heard how Mary, Queen of Scots was crowned as a baby in the castle chapel. Her story did not end happily at home. In 1567 she was forced from her throne and imprisoned, and her enemies needed a new monarch to crown in her place. They chose her own son, a boy of just thirteen months. And they crowned him not in the castle above, but down here, in this town church, on the twenty ninth of July, 1567. He became James the Sixth of Scotland, and later, when the two crowns joined, James the First of England as well.

The sermon that day was preached by John Knox, the fierce leader of Scotland's Protestant reformation, the same firebrand you may hear about on the Royal Mile in Edinburgh. He chose a Bible story about a boy king crowned after a wicked queen is pushed aside, which was not exactly subtle. So your day has a neat symmetry: the mother crowned as a baby up the hill, the son crowned as a baby down the hill, the two ceremonies barely twenty four years apart.

Outside, the graveyard tumbles down the slope, packed with the tilting, weathered headstones of Stirling's

merchants and ministers and soldiers. One last curiosity. For nearly three hundred years, from 1656 until 1936, a solid wall ran straight across the inside of this church, splitting it into two separate churches for two separate congregations who did not much care for one another. Very Scottish, that. And besides Westminster Abbey, this is the only church still in use in all of Britain to have hosted a coronation.

The Old Town Jail

A little further down the hill stands a grim, castle-like building with a round tower, and it has a suitably grim history. This is the Old Town Jail, and if it is open you can go in and be shown round by a costumed guide playing a Victorian jailer, which the children will either love or find delightfully alarming.

To understand why it was built, you have to know what came before it. For centuries, Stirling's prisoners were held in the Tolbooth, down in the marketplace, a cramped, filthy, stinking hole. In 1842 a prison inspector visited and declared it, in writing, one of the worst jails in the whole of Britain. That was embarrassing enough to force action, and in 1847 this new jail opened, designed by an Edinburgh architect named Thomas Brown.

It was, believe it or not, meant to be an improvement, even a reform. It followed a strict new idea called the separate system. Every prisoner had his own individual cell, and the whole point was silence and separation. Prisoners were kept apart so they could not teach one another bad habits, set to hard work, and taught to read. In theory it was humane. In practice, being kept in near total silence and solitude, day after day, month after month, drove some prisoners to despair, and a few clean out of their minds. Reform and cruelty, wearing the very same uniform.

The jail later became a military prison, holding soldiers from the castle garrison up above until the 1930s, and then it fell into ruin before being rescued and turned into the visitor attraction it is today. As you are led from cell to cell you will hear about the hangman, the punishments, the escape attempts, and the everyday misery of Victorian imprisonment. It is vivid, a little theatrical, and a useful reminder that the pretty town you are strolling through was, for the people who broke its laws, not pretty in the slightest.

Two Great Houses: Mar's Wark and Argyll's Lodging

Near the top of the town, two grand houses tell you how Scotland's nobles lived when they were not inside the castle. The great and the powerful needed to be close to the king, but a royal fortress is a cramped and drafty place to stay. So the richest built themselves town palaces just outside the gates, and two of them survive here.

The first, and you cannot possibly miss it, is Mar's Wark, that enormous, ornate stone facade straddling the top of the street. Wark simply means work, or building. It was raised around 1570 by John Erskine, Earl of Mar, who held one of the great hereditary jobs in all of Scotland, keeper of Stirling Castle. His family guarded the fortress and helped raise the royal children inside it for generations. So Mar built himself a showpiece right at the castle gate, dripping with carved figures and coats of arms, deliberately echoing the Renaissance palace up the hill. The story goes that he pinched much of the stone from a nearby abbey that had fallen out of use, and you can still spot a carved cross in the masonry that seems to back the tale up. It was never quite finished, war and politics got in the way, and today only that magnificent front wall remains, like a stage set with almost nothing behind it.

Just a little way off is Argyll's Lodging, and this one is complete, the finest surviving town house of its era anywhere in Scotland. Walk into its courtyard and you step straight into the seventeenth century. Its grandest owner was Sir William Alexander, a poet and courtier who was made Earl of Stirling, and who lavished a fortune turning it into a private palace fit to receive the king, Charles the First. It very nearly ruined him, and he died deep in debt. Later the house passed to the powerful Campbell Earls of Argyll, whose name it still carries today.

Between them, these two houses make the point beautifully. Up the hill, the crown lived in stone and splendour. Down here, the nobles built their own smaller splendours as close to the throne as they could possibly get, because in that world, nearness to the king was everything.

The Market Cross and the Heart of the Town

Carry on down and the street opens out into Broad Street, and this was the heart of old Stirling, the marketplace. Close your eyes for a moment and fill it in: stalls and awnings, the shouts of traders, the smell of fish and tallow and animal dung, cloth merchants and shoemakers and fleshers, that is butchers, all crowded along one steep, cobbled street.

At its centre stands the Mercat Cross, the market cross. Every Scottish burgh had one, and it was far more than decoration. This was the town's official centre, the place where markets were licensed, where royal proclamations were read out to the crowd, where deals were struck, and where people gathered, sometimes to cheer and sometimes to riot. On top of the cross sits a stone unicorn, Scotland's royal beast, and the locals have affectionately called it the Puggy for generations. The unicorn is the genuine old survivor, carved back in the fifteen hundreds. The cross beneath it was taken down and carted away for about a hundred years before finally being put back where it belonged.

Looming over the square is the Tolbooth. Now, a tolbooth was the Swiss Army knife of a Scottish town. It was the town hall, where the council met. It was the courthouse, where justice was handed out. It was the place where taxes and tolls were collected, which is exactly where the name comes from. And it was the jail, the very same grim lockup that was later condemned as one of the worst in Britain, before the new jail up the hill replaced it.

Justice here was public, and it was meant to shame. A wrongdoer might be locked into the joughs, an iron collar chained to the wall or the cross, and left there for the whole market to jeer at. Others were branded, or put in the stocks, or worse. It is easy to stand in this handsome square and forget that for hundreds of years it was also the place where the town punished its own, out in the open, in front of everyone. Market, courtroom and stage of shame, all in one steep street.

The Old Bridge and the Town Walls

The last stretch of the walk takes you down toward the River Forth and the Old Bridge, and this is where the whole day comes full circle. Up in the castle you heard the story of the Battle of Stirling Bridge in 1297, when Wallace and Andrew Murray let the English army file halfway across a narrow timber bridge, then destroyed the half that had crossed. That wooden bridge is long gone. But its stone successor still stands, close to where the battle was fought, and it is the handsome four-arched bridge you see before you.

It is around five hundred years old, built in the late fourteen hundreds or the early fifteen hundreds, and for centuries it was the great gateway to the north, the lowest bridge over the Forth, the very chokepoint that made Stirling so important in the first place. Every drover, merchant and army heading into the Highlands crossed here, pausing at the toll gates that once stood at each end. And it very nearly had a violent moment of its own. In 1745, when Bonnie Prince Charlie and his Jacobite army came marching, the governor of the castle ordered the southern arch of this bridge to be blown up to stop them crossing. It worked. The Jacobites had to wade the river elsewhere, and the broken arch was patched up again a few years later.

As you walk, look out for the old town wall, the best preserved burgh wall in all of Scotland. It connects straight back to your castle visit. Those walls went up in a tremendous hurry around 1547, and the reason was the very same war you heard about up above, the Rough Wooing, when Henry the Eighth's armies were trying to force the infant Mary, Queen of Scots into a marriage with his son. Stirling threw up stone walls to keep the English out and to keep their little queen safe. The path that follows the wall is called

the Back Walk, one of the oldest town walkways in Britain, and it gives you a walker's view of just how well defended this town once was.

A town needed walls for the obvious reason, to keep enemies out. But walls also controlled who came in, and where, and whether they paid their tolls at the gate. So as you cross that old bridge and trace that old wall, remember you are walking the town's front door and its locked gate, the same stones that once helped decide who got into Scotland, and who did not.